

Hand In Hand

Outlook and Exchange Server team up to become a powerful collaboration suite. If you're worried about the price of Exchange, though, fret not—there are many open source alternatives to consider

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We never get tired of broaching collaboration-related topics in this section, and for good reason. No matter how much we streamline our work here at *Digit*, there's always some snag or the other that comes up—the writer finished the article, but the sub-editor didn't find out, someone forgot to tell the editor that the article was ready for print, and so on.

You won't face the exact same situations, obviously, but unless everyone's reading each other's minds in your organisation, there's scope for improvement.

Half The Client

What do you use Outlook for? If you're connecting to a POP or IMAP server to get your e-mail, then chances are you're using it for the same thing that the majority does—checking your mail, managing your contacts, and perhaps a bit of personal management. The bottom line is that you're using it as a *personal* tool, and the only way it's helping you interact with your team is through e-mail.

We've touched on the benefits of pairing up Outlook with Microsoft Exchange Server a couple of times in these pages; read on now to find out what those benefits really are.

Meeting At 10... er... 11... er...

Setting up meetings via e-mail can be painful. Imagine this scenario: you've sent your team a message to meet at 11.00 AM. While everyone's busy clearing and/or readjusting his or her schedules, one person replies, saying that he'll be on an outdoor assignment at that time.

You now have to reschedule the meeting, taking your own free time into account—and what if you get the dreaded "I'm not free" reply again?

Assuming you've got everyone to plan their work day in Outlook's calendar, having an Exchange server at your office will enable you to see everyone's free and busy times, so you'll never have to encounter the above situation.

You don't even need to hunt down attendees' schedules—just add them in the list and tell Outlook to hunt for a date and time combination when everyone's free!

You can also manage meeting rooms in Exchange, to avoid those situations where everyone's ready but there's nowhere to hold the meeting.

Worried about what will happen to all your important correspondence while you're gone?

Call Upon Your Minions

One of the features that Outlook gives vacationing employees is the ability to add a delegate for all their daily activities—someone who will reply to your e-mail, ensure that all tasks (discussed later) are either completed or followed up, and so on.

You can decide which of your mail folders delegates have access to (don't let them near your Personal folders, now), as well as whether or not they can create new tasks for your team. All these activities are tracked, so you can check up on what your delegate was up to while you were gone. Apart from being really convenient, that last bit should feed your Big Brother instincts quite well, too.

Remember the Tasks you can set yourself in Outlook? With an Exchange Server, you can set tasks for not only yourself, but also anyone in your team—complete with deadline and follow-up reminder. Managing people just got so much easier.

Another Outlook feature that Exchange "unlocks" is the ability to create public folders or mailboxes, where you can store important (or unimportant) mails so that everyone has access to them.